Country Profile: Mauritania

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 4
- Plurality religion: Islam
- Official language: French (1960–1978); Arabic (1968–2020)
- Official religion: Islam
- Core group: White Moors (1960–1981)

Historical Background

Starting in the 20th century, Mauritania was under French colonial control as part of French West Africa. It became independent in 1960 when the North, under indirect French colonial control, joined the South, under direct French control administered from neighboring Senegal. Between 1976 and 1979 Mauritania briefly occupied a part of Western Sahara after Spain ceded its control over the territory to Morocco and Mauritania. Since it never managed to achieve de facto control over the territory and even struggled to control the territory within its own borders during this period, it eventually relinquished this part to Morocco in 1979.[1] Sahrawis are therefore considered a group in Mauritania from 1976 to 1979, impacting the sizes of the other groups in the country during this time.

Mauritania officially abolished slavery in 1981, but informal practices persisted well into the 21st century. It was not until the 2007 amendments to the Penal Code that slavery was formally criminalized. While there is no evidence that the central government legally enforced slavery after its abolition, it remained a deeply rooted tradition within the Moor community, continuing to affect society into the late 20th and early 21st centuries.

Groups

A general note on group sizes in Mauritania

The government of Mauritania has declined to disclose census data regarding the ethnic makeup of the country due to internal conflicts. As a result, it is challenging

[1] EPR Atlas, 2021.

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to acquire accurate population information on Mauritania's ethnic groups. Since EPR and AMAR group percentages vary greatly between decades—fluctuations which we were unable to explain adequately—we decided to use the CIA Factbook percentages for White Moors, Black Moors, and Black Africans available from the 1980s and assign the same percentages for the earlier decades as well. We also consider Sahrawis as a group, estimated at 7% of the population by EPR, in the country from 1976 to 1979 during Mauritania's partial occupation of Western Sahara. We changed the percentages of the remaining groups in this period accordingly: 27.9% in the cases of White Moors and Black Africans, and 37.2% for Haratins.

A general note on Moors

In the 17th century, Berbers made their last attempt at expelling Beni Hassan Arabs from the territory of today's Mauritania. Unsuccessful, the effort resulted in a cultural fusion of two groups, the descendants of which are today known as Moors or Arab-Berbers. The dominant group in this slave-owning society were **White Moors**, locally known as **Beydan**, while the descendants of their slaves are known as **Black Moors**, or **Haratins**.[2] Both groups speak Hassaniya Arabic and practice Islam. White Moors represent around 30% of the population, and Black Moors 40%.

The racial difference between the two groups is not as clear as their names suggest and was a result of colonial racial classification, which categorized Moors into White and Black by the color of their skin, but more particularly based on their position in society as either master or slave.[3] We have coded both groups as racial groups in the colonial and post-independence periods because the names of the groups refer to racial phenotypes, and colonial racial policy treated them as such with evidence that racial categories have persisted in the post-independence period as well.

- **White Moors** historically occupied the upper echelons of Mauritanian society. They are the descendants of Arabo-Berber conquerors called Mourabitounes, after whom the Mauritanian state acquired its name.[4] Since independence, they have continued to dominate the country both politically and economically under the dictatorial regime of President Moktar Ould

[2] Minority Rights, 2019.
[3] Joshua Project, 2024.
[4] EPR Atlas, 2021.

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Daddah (1960–1978) and his Parti du Peuple Mauritanien (PPM).[5] We consider White Moors to be a core group of Mauritania in the immediate post-independence period between 1960 and 1981, when slavery was abolished and their dominance, at least in theory, was thus somewhat reduced.

- At the time of the country's independence, slavery was still a common and accepted practice in Mauritania. As society was becoming increasingly "Arabized," **Black Moors**, as members of a shared Arab-Berber culture, began to make increasing demands on the state to end the practice. Mauritania finally abolished slavery in 1981, the last country in the world to do so, but the practice continued and was only criminalized in 2007.[6] Despite sharing religious and linguistic markers of common ancestry, the Black Moors population in Mauritania has experienced ongoing marginalization with limited protection from the government and other stakeholders, leaving them vulnerable to exploitation and discrimination.
- **Black Africans/ Kewri** is a nested group composed of the **Peul**, **Wolof**, and **Mande** subgroups. The Mande, in its turn, include the Soninke and a smaller share of Bambara sub-ethnicities. The languages associated with these subgroups are Pulaar, Wolof, and Soninke. Members of the Black African group are mainly concentrated in the southern part of Mauritania, along the border with neighboring Senegal and Mali. The size of the group is around 11%. Evaluating the size of the Black Africans group over time has been challenging, as members of this group are often overlooked due to ongoing discrimination and persecution by the Mauritanian government, including expulsions, confiscation of land and property, and extrajudicial killings.
- **Sahrawis** are included as a group in Mauritania from 1976 to 1979, when Mauritania briefly occupied the territory of Western Sahara after Spain ceded its control to Morocco and Mauritania. According to EPR, the size of the group in Mauritania is 7% of the population. They speak Moroccan Arabic and are concentrated in the Western Sahara. There are around 26,000 Sahrawi refugees living in Mauritania today,[7] which would amount to around 0.5% of

[5] Minority Rights, 2019, EPR Atlas, 2021.
[6] Minority Rights, 2019; Ordonnance No. 81-234 du 9 Novembre 1981 portant Abolition de l'Esclavage.
[7] UNHCR, 2009.

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its population, but we are only considering the group as included during the occupation period between 1976–1979.

State Profile

Official Language

The 1959 Constitution of Mauritania, in force at the time of the country's independence, established French as the official language of the state.[8] The 1968 amendment to the Constitution of 1961 introduced (Standard) Arabic alongside French as the official language.[9] The 1978 Constitutional Charter revised the language provision. Henceforth, only Arabic has been recognized as the country's official language, without any references to French in the Constitution.[10]

Official Religion

Mauritania is officially an Islamic state. The 1959 Constitution first established this principle, which has been reiterated in every subsequent governing document.[11]

Education Policies

The current educational system in Mauritania begins with pre-primary education for children aged 4 to 6, primarily focused on Koranic studies. Formal primary education, which is mandatory and free for all, starts at age 6 and lasts for six years. The first four years of secondary education, known as Lower Secondary School or Middle School, take place in colleges, where students follow a general academic curriculum and must pass the Brevet d'Etudes du Premier Cycle to advance. The final three years are completed at Lycées, where students choose specialized programs, with the goal of obtaining a baccalaureate, which is necessary for university admission.[12] Private schools are allowed and generally follow the curriculum of public schools.

Language Education Policies

The 1959 education reform institutionalized French and Standard Arabic (macrolanguage of Hassaniyya Arabic) as languages of instruction in all public

[8] Constitution of Mauritania, 1959.
[9] Constitutional Law No. 68-065 of March 4, 1968.
[10] Constitutional Charter of the Military Committee for National Reconstruction, 1978.
[11] Constitution of Mauritania, 1959.
[12] Scholaro, 2024.

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primary and secondary schools. Hassaniyya Arabic as such is not mentioned in any legal text. Pulaar, Wolof and Soninke are not taught in Mauritanian schools.[13]

Through the subsequent educational reforms of 1967, 1973, and 1978, the state sought to further strengthen the position of Standard Arabic by increasing the teaching hours in the language as part of its policy of Arabization.[14] The 1999 Law No. 99012, enacted on April 26, mandated that Arabic be the sole language of instruction for all first-year students in both public and private schools, with French introduced as a subject starting from the second year. Since the law permits other languages of instruction after the first year, it was not listed as a restriction on language instruction in private schools. However, the measure indicates the state's policy of gradual Arabization.

Religious Education Policies

It is not entirely certain when Islamic education became a mandatory class in Mauritania's public schools, so we coded independence "with uncertainty" as the start date. The same requirements apply for private schools, where Islamic education is mandatory for the whole post-independence period. However, attendance at Islamic classes was no longer mandatory for all students in public schools after 2016, according to the US Department of State's report on religious freedom in Mauritania.[15]

Demographic Engineering and Violence

A general note on slavery

Although slavery was only officially abolished in 1981, we do not consider this as a case of legally mandated segregation. There is no evidence that enslavement was ever legally enforced by the central state; rather, it was a traditional practice in the Moor community has persisted into the late 20th and early 21st centuries.

State-Based Violence

General note on Black Africans/Kewri

Although there is evidence of violence against civilian members of the Black Africans nested group conducted on the part of the Mauritanian government,

[13] L'Aménagement Linguistique dans le Monde, 2024.
[14] Ibid.
[15] US Department of State, 2020.

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particularly arbitrary executions of the Peul ethnic group, the numbers do not reach the threshold of 100 non-combatant deaths established by the NBP. According to UCDP data, they amount to 25 in 1989 and 30 in 1990. Further, hundreds of Kewri political prisoners were killed, though they were members of armed militias and not civilians.[16]

Forced Relocations

Mauritania expelled between 70,000 and 85,000 members of the Black Africans nested group to Senegal and Mali in 1989, according to the GSME Event Data Dataset.[17] Evidence suggests that forced expulsions, which started as a border dispute between Senegal and Mauritania, concerned the Peul and Mande ethnic groups in particular, which the government claimed were Senegalese and not Mauritanian nationals. Extrajudicial executions, torture, and property confiscations accompanied the expulsions.

Constitutions and Laws

Constitutional Provisions

Between 1945 and 2020, Mauritania was governed by six different Constitutions. The 1959 Constitution does not mention any groups. Article 3 of the Constitution establishes French as the official language of the state. Article 2 recognizes the freedom of conscience and the universal liberty of religious practice. It also establishes Islam as the official religion.[18]

The 1961 Constitution repeats the provisions from the 1959 Constitution adding the recognition of Arabic as a national language in Article 3. French continued as the sole official language.[19]

The 1968 amendment was important as it revised Article 3 of the 1961 Constitution elevating Arabic to the status of an official language together with French.[20]

Following a coup d'etat in 1978 deposing president Moktar Ould Daddah, the new military government inaugurated the Constitutional Charter of the Military

[16] Human Rights Watch, 1994.
[17] Garrity, 2022; Amnesty International, 1989; Minority Rights, 2019.
[18] Constitution of Mauritania, 1959.
[19] Constitution of Mauritania, 1961.
[20] Constitutional Law No. 68-065 of March 4, 1968.

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Committee for National Reconstruction, which acted as an interim constitution. The Charter does not mention any groups. Article 6 establishes Arabic as the only official language of the state, with no mention of French. Wolof, Pulaar, and Soninke are recognized as national, but not official, languages of the state. Article 1 of the Mauritanian Constitution declares the country an Islamic state and establishes Islam as the official state religion, while Article 5 recognizes individual freedom of conscience.[21]

The 1978 Constitutional Charter was superseded by the 1980 Constitutional Charter, which also served an interim role. This Charter does not reference any specific ethnic groups, official languages, or religion. However, the Preamble includes a reference to Allah, reaffirming Mauritania's status as an Islamic state.[22] Likewise, the subsequent 1985 Constitutional Charter, which also functioned as an interim constitution, does not mention any specific groups or official language. Nevertheless, it explicitly declares Islam as the official state religion.[23]

The 1991 Constitution marked the end of military rule in place since the first 1978 coup d'etat. While the document does not recognize any ethnic group in particular, the preamble does make a general reference to Mauritanian people as Muslim, Arab, and African. Arabic is established as the official language, while Pulaar, Soninke, and Wolof are designated as national languages under Article 6. Freedom of religion is not mentioned, while Islam is endorsed as the official state religion.[24]

Citizenship Laws

Access to Mauritanian nationality is governed by two main laws: the Mauritanian Nationality Code of 1961 (Law No. 1961-112) and the Law No. 2010-023 of 2010.[25] The 1961 Law originally granted children born in Mauritania to foreign parents to acquire nationality if they had lived in the country for at least five years. In 2010, this provision was removed. The new Article 18 introduced a 10-year residency requirement for naturalization, which is reduced to five years for those born in Mauritania. This change means that birth in the country no longer confers birthright citizenship but instead facilitates the naturalization process. (The two nationality

[21] Constitutional Charter of the Military Committee for National Reconstruction, 1978.
[22] Constitutional Charter of December 12, 1980.
[23] Constitutional Charter of February, 1985.
[24] Constitution of Mauritania, 1991.
[25] Mauritanian Nationality Code of 1961; Law No. 2010-023 of 2010 repealing and replacing certain provisions of Law 61-112 of June 12, 1961 on the Mauritanian Nationality Code.

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laws also include language provisions for acquiring citizenship; however, there is no distinction in the treatment of different groups and their associated languages.) Accordingly, the 1961 law required fluency in one of the following languages: Toucouleur (associated with the Peul subgroup of the Black Africans nested group), Sarakole (associated with the Mande subgroup of the Black Africans nested group), Wolof, Bambara (associated with the Mande subgroup of the Black Africans nested group), Hassaniya Arabic, Standard Arabic, and French. In 2010, the requirement was amended to mandate fluency in Arabic, Pulaar, Soninke, or Wolof, excluding French. This change reflects a shift towards Arabization and a greater emphasis on local languages over the colonial influence of French.

National Anthem(s)

Since independence, Mauritania has had two national anthems in place. The first has been in use since 1960. Based on an 18th-century poem by Baba Ould Cheikh, its title is نشيد وطني موريتاني, which simply translates to the "National Anthem of Mauritania." It was written in Arabic, which is interesting since the official language of the Mauritanian state at the time was French.[26] The anthem makes a religious reference, starting out with the verse, "Be a helper for God" according to the English translation of the original text. In 2017, following a national referendum on national symbols, the anthem was replaced by a composition with a similar title, شيد وطني موريتاني", translated to English as the "National Anthem of Mauritania," the same title as the 1960 text. It was also written in Arabic. The 2017 anthem makes blood references to nation and martyrdom: "(w)e will protect your blood, we sacrifice for you"; to enemies: "(w)e made your enemy drink a bitter downpour"; and religious references: "(t)he fortress of the Book that can't be bound, (w)e followed the prophet along the path of the heavens."

[26] Nationalanthems.info.

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